

English dreams: On language debate and English medium education

Imposing any language as the medium of instruction **is** unacceptable

English medium education is an **aspiration** for many Indians, but **state policy** regarding the medium of instruction **has** been **uneven** across time and regions. The **ongoing** language **debate** in India, which **stems from** the **renewed** efforts of the Bharatiya Janata Party to **enforce** a three-language policy, **has** many components, the medium of instruction being one. **Educationists** generally **argue** that **instruction** in the mother tongue **helps** children achieve better learning goals in their early stages of development. This view is supported by **pedagogical** research, but it cannot, and does not, operate **in isolation** from other factors such as constitutional rights and ground realities. India's **linguistic diversity** and distribution is such that even the **question** of what is a child's mother tongue **can often** be a **contested** one. There is also the constitutional question of freedom of expression and choice. In 2014, after a **protracted** legal **tussle**, the Supreme Court of India **held** that a Karnataka government **order** of 1994 that made instruction in Kannada mandatory until Class four **was** not **valid** under the Constitution. For, children have a right to choose, and the state cannot enforce its view on what is good for them. The **rights** of private educational institutions to offer education as per market demand **are** another related issue.

The National Education Policy that is being **aggressively** pushed by the Centre has a particularly anti-English **edge**, which is not **in line with** popular aspiration. **Many States** that want to promote their local language and culture also **want** to promote English education and English as a medium of instruction. In Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala and Tamil Nadu, there are **aided** English medium schools. The **demand** for English medium education **is** growing — this includes the Hindi-speaking regions — which is **met** largely by **substandard** and expensive private institutions. English skills help individuals and the country in **gaining a place** in the global services sector. India's **subaltern** caste groups **in particular seek** to **empower** themselves through English education, which remains a **currency** for **upward mobility**. If state schools do not offer English medium instruction, relatively richer families could still access it through private schools. In this context, education becomes a continuing reproduction and even **aggravation** of **social inequalities**, which is the exact opposite of its purpose. The fact is that **knowledge** of English **is** empowering and convertible for other **outcomes**. There can be a debate on whether it should be the medium of instruction at the primary level, but a basic test of any policy is in how it **advances** the ambitions of the most **disadvantaged** sections.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

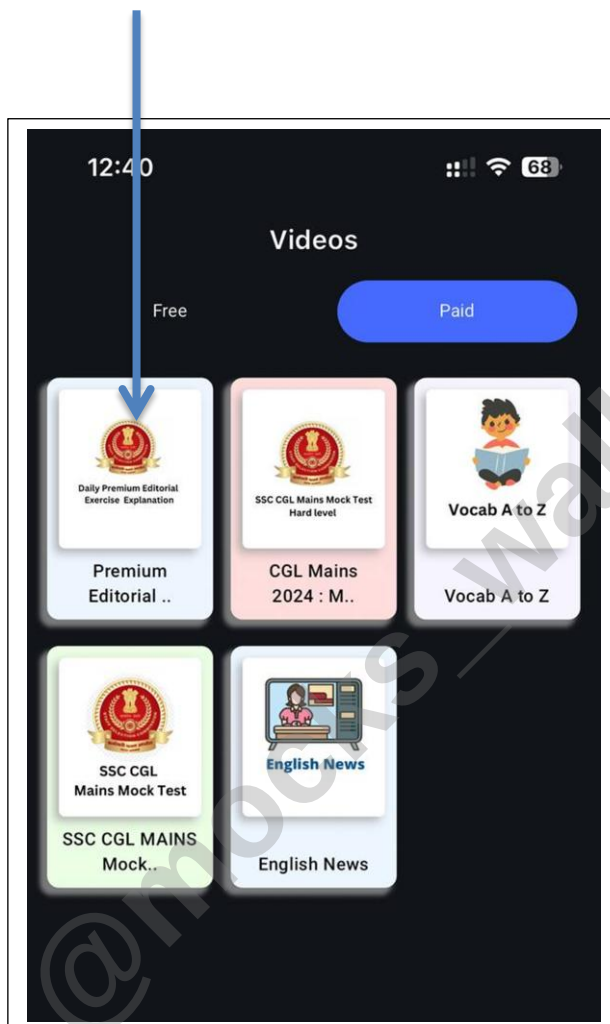
[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Debate** (noun) – discussion, argument, deliberation, dispute, controversy बहस
2. **Impose** (verb) – enforce, inflict, dictate, compel, mandate थोपना
3. **Aspiration** (noun) – ambition, goal, desire, dream, objective आकांक्षा
4. **Uneven** (adjective) – inconsistent, irregular, patchy, fluctuating, unbalanced असमान
5. **Ongoing** (adjective) – continuing, in progress, current, persistent, active जारी
6. **Stem** (from) (verb) – originate, arise, derive, emerge, come from उत्पन्न होना / निकलना
7. **Renewed** (adjective) – revived, refreshed, restarted, repeated, reinitiated पुनः प्रारंभ
8. **Enforce** (verb) – implement, impose, administer, uphold, apply लागू करना
9. **Educationist** (noun) – educator, academic, pedagogue, teacher, education reformer शिक्षाविद
10. **Argue** (verb) – contend, claim, assert, reason, maintain तर्क करना
11. **Pedagogical** (adjective) – educational, instructional, academic, teaching-related शैक्षिक / शिक्षाशास्त्रीय
12. **In isolation** (phrase) – separately, alone, independently, apart, exclusively अकेले में / अलग से
13. **Linguistic** (adjective) – language-related, philological, grammatical भाषाई
14. **Diversity** (noun) – variety, multiplicity, range, difference, heterogeneity विविधता
15. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, many times, regularly, repeatedly अक्सर
16. **Contested** (adjective) – disputed, challenged, controversial, arguable विवादित
17. **Protracted** (adjective) – lengthy, prolonged, extended, drawn-out लंबा / खिंचा हुआ
18. **Tussle** (noun) – struggle, conflict, fight, dispute, quarrel संघर्ष / झगड़ा
19. **Hold** (verb) – declare, rule, state, assert, affirm निर्णय देना / कहना
20. **Valid** (adjective) – lawful, legal, sound, acceptable, legitimate वैध
21. **Aggressively** (adverb) – forcefully, assertively, strongly, vigorously आक्रामक रूप से
22. **Edge** (noun) – tendency, inclination, tone, direction रुझान / प्रवृत्ति

23. **In line with** (phrase) – consistent with, in agreement with, according to के अनुरूप
24. **Aided** (adjective) – government-supported, subsidized, assisted, backed सहायता प्राप्त
25. **Meet** (verb) – fulfill, satisfy, address, match, cater to पूरा करना / संतुष्ट करना
26. **Substandard** (adjective) – inferior, poor, low-grade, deficient, below par घटिया
27. **Gain a place** (phrase) – earn a position, secure a role, find recognition, achieve status स्थान प्राप्त करना
28. **Subaltern** (adjective) – oppressed, lower-class, marginalized, subordinate, underprivileged पिछड़े / निम्नवर्गीय
29. **In particular** (phrase) – especially, specifically, notably, particularly विशेष रूप से
30. **Seek** (verb) – try for, pursue, strive for, aim for, attempt प्रयास करना
31. **Empower** (verb) – enable, authorize, strengthen, uplift, support सशक्त बनाना
32. **Currency** (noun) – importance, acceptance, value, relevance, influence महत्व
33. **Upward mobility** (noun) – social advancement, rise in status, economic progress, improvement सामाजिक प्रगति
34. **Aggravation** (noun) – worsening, intensification, escalation, deterioration, increase बढ़ोतरी / बिगड़ाव
35. **Social inequality** (noun) – disparity, social imbalance, economic gap, class division सामाजिक असमानता
36. **Outcome** (noun) – result, consequence, effect, output, product परिणाम
37. **Advance** (verb) – promote, progress, further, foster, improve आगे बढ़ाना
38. **Disadvantaged** (adjective) – underprivileged, deprived, poor, marginalized, backward वंचित / पिछड़े

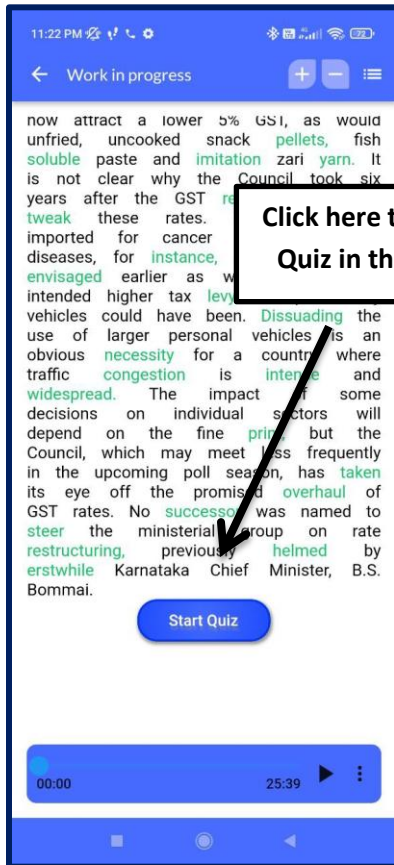
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



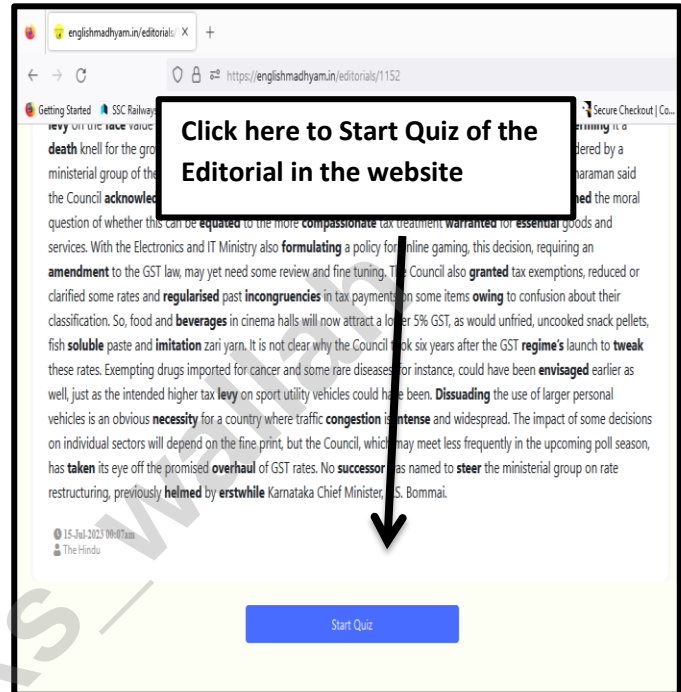
Summary of the Editorial

1. **English as Aspiration:** English medium education is widely desired in India for its role in upward mobility and global opportunities.
2. **Inconsistent Language Policies:** State policies on medium of instruction have varied across regions and over time, lacking uniformity.
3. **Three-Language Policy Controversy:** The BJP's push for the three-language policy has reignited the debate on language and education.
4. **Mother Tongue Argument:** Educationists and research advocate early education in the mother tongue for better learning outcomes.
5. **Ground Realities Complicate Theory:** In practice, factors like constitutional rights and linguistic diversity complicate a mother tongue-only approach.
6. **Defining 'Mother Tongue' is Complex:** Due to India's linguistic diversity, identifying a child's actual mother tongue can itself be contentious.
7. **Supreme Court's 2014 Ruling:** The SC invalidated Karnataka's 1994 rule enforcing Kannada medium till Class 4, upholding freedom of choice.
8. **Right to Choose Medium of Instruction:** Children and parents have the constitutional right to choose the medium of education.
9. **Private Schools and Market Demand:** Private institutions must be allowed to operate based on demand, including offering English medium instruction.
10. **NEP's Anti-English Tilt:** The National Education Policy being promoted by the Centre appears to undermine English, which is against public aspirations.
11. **States' Mixed Approach:** States like Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu promote both regional languages and English.
12. **Growing Demand Across India:** Even in Hindi-speaking areas, the demand for English medium schools is rising sharply.
13. **Inequity in Access:** English medium education is often only accessible through costly private schools, excluding poorer families.
14. **English as Empowerment:** Especially for subaltern caste groups, English offers empowerment and a means for socio-economic mobility.
15. **Policy Must Uplift the Disadvantaged:** Language policy should be evaluated by how well it supports the ambitions of the most marginalized communities.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



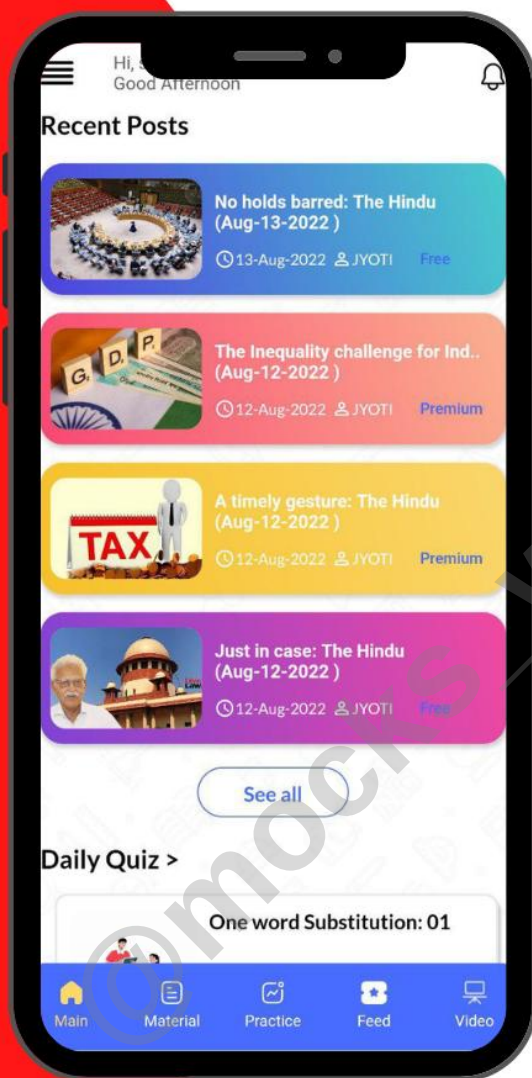
Click here to Start
Quiz in the App



Click here to Start Quiz of the
Editorial in the website

[Click here to download App](#)

[Click here to visit website](#)



Learn Vocabulary Through Reading Articles

English Madhyam